

GOOSE & GANDER

The first fortnightly deep-clean, I told them to dig out those yellowed uniforms.

The ones that were already stained beyond saving. The ones that finally had a purpose.

They nodded. Said yes, Chef. Went back to their stations.

But when the day came and I walked out of the kitchen toward my office, I caught the look. Quick glances between sections. The kind of silent conversation that happens when a brigade thinks they're about to get fucked.

Here we go. He's bailing.

Knew it.

Same as the last one.

I could feel it without turning around. The energy shift. The disappointment settling in before anything had even happened.

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I came back in old jeans and a ratty t-shirt.

The whole kitchen went quiet.

Then someone laughed — not at me, just in surprise — and suddenly they were all talking at once. Grinning. Elbowing each other. The mood flipped so fast it was almost disorienting.

Sonny was already breaking down the six-top burner. I climbed up under the range hood, started pulling filters, passed them down to him.

"You gonna stare or you gonna scrub?"

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Same rule the vineyard gave me — it just cost more now the kitchen was mine.

You can't demand what you won't demonstrate.

I was lucky. My foundations came from chefs who lived that without ever saying it. Sam scrubbing pans at 2 a.m. when the dishie was buried. Chef staying back to fix a station he could've just bollocked someone for. They never announced it. Never made it a lesson. It was just what you did.

But the kitchens I inherited? The ones I got handed because no one else wanted to fix them?

Those told a different story.

Chefs who'd barked about standards from the pass but never touched a mop. Sous chefs who'd ream you for mise that wasn't perfect while their own section looked like a crime scene. People who thought the title meant they'd graduated from the work instead of just becoming responsible for more of it.

You could feel it the moment you walked in. The resentment. The hollowness. Everyone doing the minimum because why the fuck would you give more than someone who won't give anything themselves?

That's what coasting looks like. Not in the food — in the air.

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There's a phrase I heard somewhere along the way. Might've been my mother. Might've been a chef. Might've just been something I read and forgot the source of.

ChefTip #5

"What's good for the goose is good for the gander."

Same rules. Same standard. Top to bottom.

You want your team to show up in clean whites? Show up in clean whites.

You want them to taste everything before it leaves the pass? Taste everything before it leaves the pass.

You want them to scrub grout on a Sunday? Get down on your fucking knees and scrub grout on a Sunday.

Leadership isn't standing above. It's standing with.

You can hold a title and still be part of the brigade. You can run a kitchen and still empty a fryer. You can be *Chef* and still scrub floors when that's what the kitchen needs.

The standard you set is the standard you live. No exceptions.

The moment you start exempting yourself — the moment you decide the title means you've earned the right to stop doing the hard shit — you lose the room.

Maybe not immediately. Maybe not loudly.

But you lose it.

Because your team is watching. Not for your words — for your actions. They're clocking every moment you could've pulled rank and didn't. Every time you did the shit job alongside them instead of delegating it and disappearing.

That's how trust gets built. Plate by plate. Shift by shift. One scrubbing brush at a time.

Don't forget where you came from.

Don't forget you're still one of them.

And never — not once — ask for something you're not willing to give yourself.

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The bistro ran itself by the end.

That's the strange thing about building something properly — eventually it doesn't need you anymore. The team I'd trained could handle whatever walked through the door. The standards were theirs now, not just mine.

Which meant it was time to go.

Not up. Sideways.

Melbourne. A fine dining Italian place that had been making noise for years. They needed a CDP for pasta section.

I took the job. Took the pay cut. Dropped back down the ladder I'd just climbed.

Because running a kitchen is one thing. But I still didn't know pasta. Not really. Not the way I wanted to.

And the only way to learn something properly is to go somewhere that demands it.